STRANGE LAND

A story about escape…
By Percy Pham

CHAPTER 1: THE CAPTURE

EXT. TRIPLE O'S DRIVE-IN - EARLY MORNING 4 A.M
THEO tore into the white paper bag the second he stepped out of the joint. He looked like he'd been dragged through the last twenty-four hours, his clothes stained, and a heavy, glazed exhaustion hanging over his eyes.

He moved with a slight limp, so starved and hurt that he couldn't even wait to get somewhere else, grabbing greased and salted fries by the handful. So starved that THEO didn't notice the black Suburban idling at the curb.

Yup, always the man with the worst timing, right when he unwrapped the burger, when two well-dressed fellas just showed up and walked towards him. Being cornered against the wall, he just threw the untouched burger towards one of them and attempted to make a run.

LEON (angrily)
That's my favorite shirt.

Two of them jumped at THEO and shoved him to the wall. One of them grabbed him at once, one arm around his chest, the other trying to clamp over his mouth and head.

TRACE (breathing heavily)
Hold still.

TRACE guy patted his pockets, then looked around.
Where's the zip tie?

LEON
What do you mean, where's the zip tie?

TRACE
I didn’t bring it. Did you?

LEON
No, I had a bag.

He stomped hard on one man’s foot, drove an elbow backward at the one holding him, and bit on the hand covering his mouth.

TRACE
F*ck

LEON
F*ck the zip tie, just get the bag over him.

A rough brown sack was finally pulled over his head. Just as they finished tying him up, a bunch of zip ties slipped out of the bag and dropped to the ground.

TRACE
Found it.

LEON
Found what?

TRACE
The f*king zip tie.

LEON
Just shut the f*ck up and get this over already.

He drove a punch into his stomach, sending him down onto the concrete. The plastic tie snapped tight around his wrists. They shoved him forward, wrestled him through the open car door, and dumped him into the back seat.

INT. BLACK SUBURBAN
TRACE was driving, and LEON sat in the passenger seat.

LEON (scrubbed his white t-shirt with wet wipes)
What's in this ketchup? Seriously, a wet wipe is not doing jack sh*t.

TRACE
Probably sugar and food dye.

LEON
That’s it, food dye. F*ck, this is brand new.

TRACE
It's a $15 t-shirt. You look like you just got back from a toddler's birthday party, not a professional grab-and-go.

LEON
Yeah, when it comes to a professional grab-and-go, one should think that we've got everything ready by the time we grab that bag-head down there.

TRACE
The f*ck? I was not the guy who prepared the stuff. You brought the bag and somehow managed to include the zip ties.

LEON angrily threw the wet wipes out of the window.
Just shut up. I’m starving from this sh*t.

TRACE
You know what I am carving for right now? From all that ketchup talk.

LEON
F*ck you. What?

TRACE
Some chicken katsu, American style.

LEON
Isn’t that just fried chicken?

TRACE
Hell yeah, die for that right now.

LEON
What with you Americans eating crap?

TRACE
What do you mean?

LEON
The fast food, f*cking everything.

TRACE
Dude, we have the best over here.

LEON
Like what?

TRACE
The foods, the freedom, and the guns.

LEON
The guns?

TRACE
Guns solved everything. You military folks should know this.

LEON
Last time I checked, that is not how guns work.

TRACE
Guns solved everything. Like, looked at that dude back there.

TRACE turned his back towards the backseat and threw a piece of crunched-up napkin towards the guy.

TRACE
You back there, THEO, right?

THEO still struck up the situation, tried to knot his head.

TRACE
What are you trying to do? Your head is in a bag, speak up!

LEON hit TRACE’s head.

LEON
Eyes on the f*cking road, TRACE.

TRACE turned his head back to the road.
Let’s try this again. You are THEO, right?

THEO is afraid and still a bit shaken.
Yes…

TRACE
Good, so we’ve got the right guy. Here’s the situation. We tried to, let’s say… bring you to the car earlier. Would it or would it not be easier for you to decide if we point a gun at you?

THEO
Easier

TRACE
Easier to WHAT?

THEO
Easier for me to decide.

TRACE
Good! You see what I mean, LEON.

LEON (sighed)
Yeah, but that doesn’t change the fact that MR. BISHOP wants to bring this guy back unharmed. Do you remember the last mission with the Duvall family?

TRACE
Yeah, that sh*t was crazy, but did we get the job done?

LEON
But that doesn’t prove anything.

TRACE
What thing?

LEON
Your argument. A gun solves everything.

TRACE
Okay, name me one thing that guns can’t solve.

LEON
The gun violence problem. How about that?

TRACE
If you really think about it, dude. You can fix the problem by having a bigger gun and telling them to drop that f*cking gun. That’s how heroes in movies usually do it.

LEON slumped against the door, pulled out a cigarette, and lit it up. His eyes were tracking a solitary goose on the roadside under the pale orange of a streetlamp. The argument had hit a wall, and LEON was too exhausted to try to argue.

This reminds TRACE of when LEON wanted to quit, but couldn't. He couldn't stand the idea of retirement, and the violence was enough for him.

TRACE (genuinely worried)
Doing okay over there, LEON?

LEON
Yeah, yeah… A harmless guy isn't a good guy. He's just useless. A hero is the one who could turn you into a f*cking red smear on the pavement if you don’t follow the rules.

TRACE (chuckled)
But on the plus side, you are right. We got off a light night. Unlike MARCO.

He then looked back at THEO, trying to hit his leg, then turned back to the road.

TRACE (CONT'D)
Am I right?

THEO was surprised by a sudden touch.
Yes… sir…

TRACE (chuckled)
Man, f*ck that. Good job kid.

LEON took a deep breath and breathed out the smoke slowly out the window.
You don't need to call us, sir. Well, maybe not to MR. BISHOP.

TRACE
We saw you eating outside earlier. Sorry about ruining the meal. If you behave, we might be able to arrange a last one. Professional courtesy

THEO panicked and felt anxious.
Am I going to die… Please, it was an accident.

LEON
To be honest, kid, after what you pulled, you may as well go out with a juicy piece of wagyu as your last meal.

TRACE
Hold on! Where is the budget talk going to happen?

LEON
Calm down. MR. BISHOP's going to kill him anyway. It's not like he's costing us anything more. And, he f*cked MARCO up.

TRACE
You know what? You are right.

The rough burlap bag scratched against his face, trapping the fear in his eye. Every bump in the road was a hammer blow to his already spinning head. Sitting here, hands zip-tied, hearing them talk about his last meal.

All he could think about was escape, and how the hell everything had gone so wrong since the incident. Underneath the panic, he caught himself wondering what he’d even ask for as his last meal.

CHAPTER 2: THE INCIDENT

EXT. 24 TH ST - INT. CAR - MORNING

THEO sat at the crossroads stop sign. His black ’04 Honda Accord was idling, holding its own on the baking asphalt of NE 14th Street. He was burnt out. His six hours of grinding through night shifts at McDonald’s had taken all the energy he had left.

That day was a Tuesday, so he had to head back to college. After that, the boxing gym. Not the kind with trainers and clean mats, but the underground kind, where you fought for peanuts and lost more often than you won.

The only good thing was that they still paid if the fight was entertaining enough, regardless of the outcome. So THEO’s goal was never just to win. It was to give them the best show he could. Anything to build a new life.

He kept thinking about his philosophy assignment: determinism vs. free will. He had to choose one side to argue, but he couldn’t. He wanted to believe that free will was real, constantly making choices and always giving it all. Yet whenever life took a turn, he told himself what happened was always going to happen. Because of that, he wasn’t sure which view he truly believed in.

And then he wondered if it even mattered. This was only worth 15 percent, while there was a 40 percent assignment later in the term. Still, he kept thinking about it. It was the only thing keeping him awake.

THEO

What to do? What to do?

He reached into the front pocket of his ripped hoodie. He should have tossed this thing months ago. He reached down to his pocket to find a fifty-cent coin. It was from a drunk rich man who had tossed it to him during his night shift as an apology after vomiting. Heads for free will, tails for fate.

THEO crossed the road and made it to the other side. Just as he started moving again, he flicked the coin into the air. For a single second, his eyes left the road, and that was all it took to miss the biker riding across the street.

CRASH

A biker went flying over the hood. He had done everything right. Stop sign obeyed. Right when he decided to go, he hit him.

Right when he started to gain consciousness and understand what was going on, THEO slammed the door open and stumbled out of the car, almost slipping as he stepped onto the ground.

THEO (panicking)
Sh*t! Sh*t, sh*t, sh*t!

He scrambled toward the biker. His breathing was shallow and ragged, a dark smear of blood pooling under his helmet.

THEO
F*ck. Please, don’t die. Please, please…

He tried to reach for his phone. THEO’s hands were shaking so violently that he nearly dropped his phone as he frantically swiped, searching for the nearest hospital.

THEO
F*ck… Stay with me.

Right when he found the place, he forced himself to move. He grabbed the man and tried to drag him to the back seat. By the time he reached the car, breathless and panicking, he saw that the door was still closed.

THEO
Sh*t

He had to lower the man back down, fumble the door open, then drag and shove him into the back seat. He ran back to the

driver’s seat and sped off, running over the bike again on his way out.

INT. DENTIST'S OFFICE - MORNING
THEO sat in the waiting area, hands around his head, staring at the floor as he tried to hide the panic in his eyes.

THEO
I brought him to the f*cking dentist.

The waiting room was too bright. It was barely 8 AM and empty. The dentist’s office always seemed to smell like antiseptic and fluoride, unlike a hospital. Even a blind man could tell the difference.

Only one nurse sat at the reception desk, talking quietly on her phone about some appointment drama, probably about THEO to her friends. It was likely the only thing that made her job interesting.

Unlike the nurse, THEO was trapped in a loop of the accident, staring blankly at the polished white tile floor and replaying everything that had happened. This was probably the worst day of his life.

THE DENTIST
Hey, kid!

The dentist’s voice cut through the noise in THEO's head. He flinched, snapping his head up. Ears still ringing.

THE DENTIST
Deep breaths, son. You’re shaking like a leaf. Just sit down. My nurse already called the paramedics. They’ll be here in five minutes.

THEO (swallowed hard)
I… I didn't mean to. I just went… and he was there.

THE DENTIST
I know… Look, you did the right thing. I don’t know exactly what happened, but you brought him here. That is better than half the hit-and-run cases you see on the news. I can give you credit for that… Besides, he’s going to be fine.

THEO took a deep breath and slowly exhaled, trying to steady himself. The dentist pulled out some paperwork.

THE DENTIST
So, while you’re calming down, fill this out. Your information and the patient’s. It’ll save time when the ambulance gets here.

THE DENTIST (chuckled while walking away)
I know his teeth are a mess after the crash, kid, but next time don’t play hero. Just call 911.

The dentist handed THEO a clinical clipboard. THEO’s pen scratched jaggedly across the paper as he filled in his own name, address, and phone number. Then he reached the 'Patient Name' field. He froze. He walked toward the register.

THEO
I don't... I don't know who he is.

THE NURSE (spoke from the desk)
Have you checked his jacket?

THEO
Oh sh*t, my bad.

He walked back and picked up the jacket. It was a nice one, a clean black track hoodie, though now it was smeared with dirt and darkened by spots of blood. Reaching into the pocket, he pulled out a heavy leather wallet.

He fumbled with the flap until it gave, sliding out a driver’s license. He stared at the name printed in bold, clean letters beside the photo of a young man with a bright, confident smile.

THEO
Tommy... Tommy Bishop.

His fingers tightened around the driver’s license, the plastic edges biting into his palm. This was not just any name. Bishop was the neighborhood mob boss, the man who controlled the underground boxing circuit where THEO fought for scraps.

By hitting Tommy, THEO had practically signed his own death warrant, especially as one of the gym’s regular fighters.

THEO
F*cked.

THEO didn’t even see the clipboard fall. The driver’s license slipped from his fingers.

He turned and ran.

Past the nurse. Past the dentist. Straight through the glass doors. He yanked at his car door once, then froze. The keys were still inside.

Panic hit harder.

So he left it. Left the car and took off down the street.

CHAPTER 3: THE EXIT

INT. OUTSIDE THEO'S APARTMENT - NOON
THEO (panicking)
Where is the key…

He fumbled desperately, patting down his pocket. His hands were slippery with sweat and fear. The metal scraped against the lock plate of the steel door of his rundown New York-style apartment.

MRS. CHEN (opened her door, voice tight)
Hey! What's with the racket, THEO?

THEO froze, key half-inserted. He didn't turn, focusing on his breathing.

THEO (forced a casual tone)
Hey, all good, MRS. CHEN. Just dropped something. Big morning.

He finally shoved the key home and twisted it hard.

MRS. CHEN
You look horrible. Everything alright with you?

THEO
No… I'm all good. You know what it is, a rough night shift.

He slammed the door shut.

THEO whispered.
Locked.

INT. THEO'S APARTMENT (ONE DAY AFTER) - 2 P.M
THEO had spent the last forty-eight hours in a state of pure paranoia. Every creak of the floorboards or distant siren on the street felt like a direct threat, a signal that MR. BISHOP's men were finally closing in. He hadn't slept, his eyes bloodshot and heavy as he paced the small confines of the room. He was trapped in a prison of his mind, certain that the moment he stepped outside, his life would be gone.

Not only that, he couldn’t even bring himself to turn on the tv or cook because any noise would pretty much doom him. He spent two days straight sitting on his bed, occasionally checking his phone for updates.

This can’t go on. He hadn't slept or eaten for two days. And, for a moment, he thought to himself: certainly nothing has happened yet, so maybe they aren't coming. Perhaps they never found the car, or the dentist didn't hand over the clipboard.

He stood up, the floorboards groaning under his weight, and stripped off the stained hoodie he'd been wearing since the accident. He pulled a fresh, clean shirt over his head and prepared to leave.

Right when he reached out, his fingers hovered just inches from the cold metal of the handle. Right as he was about to twist it, a heavy, metallic *THUD* echoed through the wooden door.

TRACE (O.S)
Hey kid. Are you in there…

LEON (O.S)
We know you’re in there, kid. Lights are off, sure, but we checked with the building manager yesterday. That meter's spinning like a windmill.

TRACE
And MRS. CHEN over there, a lovely lady, is so worried about your academics. She told us, your philosophy and math professors, that you haven't left this room for days.

THEO didn’t wait for them to kick the door in. He bolted for the window, sliding it up with a screech of rusted metal. He scrambled onto the fire escape. The iron stairs clattered under his boots as he flew down the levels, the cold night air stinging his lungs.

He hit the final landing and jumped the last six feet into the alley. It was a man with a scar across his chin and a

switchblade already flicked open, blocking his way out of the alley.

MARCO
Wrong way, kid. Unlike LEON and TRACE up there, I can actually finish the job. And, you piece of sh*t is mine.

MARCO lunged quickly. THEO dodged to the left, but the blade still caught his thigh, a searing, white-hot cut on his right leg that instantly made him limp.

THEO
F*CK!

Before MARCO could press his attack, his phone in his jacket pocket started buzzing like crazy.

MARCO
F*ck me.

He took a step back and put the phone to his ear.

MARCO
What do you want?

He paused, phone still pressed to his ear.

MARCO (CONT'D)
Nah, didn't see sh*t. Just the damn rats.

LEON (O.S)
Go up from the fire escape and check the apartment.

MARCO
I'm not taking orders from f*cking anyone. If you want to check the apartment, break the door down.

MARCO lowered his hand and hit the end-call button. For a split second, his focus slipped.

THEO stepped in off his good leg, fast and committed, reaching for MARCO’s knife wrist. His hands locked on clean, fingers clamping down, while his shoulder drove forward.

MARCO (laughed)
You little BASTARD!

It was a solid entry, the kind that should have worked. THEO got both hands on MARCO’s knife arm and drove in hard, trying to jam the strike before MARCO could bring the blade around.

But MARCO reacted instantly.

Instead of giving ground, he turned into the pressure and crashed forward, keeping his right arm tight and the knife tucked in close. At the same time, his free left hand started firing, shots after shots, one high, one low, then high again, like a boxer working inside.

THEO tried to keep control of the knife wrist, but MARCO kept forcing the distance closed, using his shoulder and upper body to block the hit

THEO could not fully straighten up. Pain kept pulling him down on his right side, his posture uneven from the injuries he had already taken. He still fought through it, bracing and trying to stay planted, thinking he could push MARCO aside and make the run to the street to find someone. MARCO, on the other hand, kept hammering at him and driving forward.

THEO adjusted his grip, his left hand locking down on the wrist to control the distance, while his right hand pushed hard against the blade, forcing it off line. MARCO was too focused on the punches coming at him to notice the angle shifting against him.

But MARCO stayed with him.

He kept pressing closer, chest to chest now, giving THEO less and less room to move. The closer MARCO got, the more dangerous the blade became for him.

THEO shifted his weight onto his injured right leg to keep from going over. That was the mistake.

Pain ripped through it. The leg gave way under him, and his whole body dropped awkwardly. As he went down, he instinctively dragged MARCO with him, still locked onto the knife arm, pulling him forward into the collapse.

At the same time, THEO lashed out with his left leg, a straight kick towards MARCO’s right leg that caused him to lose his balance.

It worked. MARCO stumbled fully onto him, the weight of the man crushing the air out of THEO’s lungs.

The knife, pinned between their bodies and twisted at the wrong angle, drove straight into MARCO’s belly.

THEO froze for a split second, eyes widening as it registered.

MARCO (grunted in pain)
You little b*tch!

THEO snapped out of it and shoved him off hard, breaking the contact instantly.

THEO caught his breath.
F*CK!

THEO stumbled away. He didn't look back, knowing this was his only opening

EXT. EDDY ST - 5 MINS
Eddy Street had a reputation everyone knew. Filling with rundown hotels with peeling paint and broken windows. Neon signs flickered over storefronts that never seemed fully open or closed, and people drifted in and out of doorways, offering things that weren't meant to be advertised.

The air smelled like weed, piss, and garbage that never quite went away. It wasn't dramatic or exaggerated, just a place where the people with nowhere else to go gathered and didn't try to hide.

People lingered in clusters along the sidewalks, some arguing, some waiting, some just watching the world pass by with tired eyes.

THEO pulled his phone out. The screen flickered with a desperate crimson warning: 5% battery. He checked his pocket and found a crumpled five and some loose change. Ten bucks. Not even enough for a clean bandage, let alone a way out of the city.

His vision blurred as a fresh spike of pain shot up from his thigh. A small figure approached him. It was a girl, short, and wrapped in layers of worn clothes. She also had a surprisingly clean, pale pink scrunchie around her wrist. She had a dirt-smudged face, but her cat-like eyes, sharp and clear, fixed on THEO.

V
Hey. You don't look so good.

He tried to stand straight, but the pain in his leg made him wince, leaning back heavily on the pawn shop wall.

THEO
I've had better nights.

She stepped closer, her expression shifting from watchful to concerned. She saw the dark stain spreading across his jeans.

V
"Oh, crap. That's a bad one."

She appeared beside him with surprising strength and helped support his weight, lowering him carefully until he was sitting against the wall instead of falling against it.

V
Don't try to walk on it.

THEO
I wasn't planning a marathon.

She crouched in front of him and looked at the cut without touching it. Just looked, the way someone does when they're used to it and not panicking about what they find.

V
How'd it happen?

THEO
Somebody with a knife.

V
Somebody specific or just a random Tuesday?

THEO (Laughed. It came out wrong, more like a cough)
Specific.

She nodded like that answered more than he said. She sat down against the wall beside him, not too close, leaving a gap between them. She pulled her knees up and looked out at the street.

A long pause. Neither of them filled it right away.

THEO (looked at her wrist)
That scrunchie.

V (glanced down at it)
What about it?

THEO
Doesn't fit you.

V (looked at him sideways)
Excuse me?

THEO
Everything else is… I don't know. Street. That thing looks like it came out of a gift bag.

She was quiet for a second. Then she adjusted it on her wrist, smoothing it with two fingers.

V
My friend gave it to me. Before tonight.

THEO didn't ask what happened before tonight. She didn't explain.

Another pause. Across the street, two men were arguing about something neither of them seemed to care about anymore. A dog barked twice from somewhere and stopped.

V
You from here?

THEO
No. Compton.

V
Long way to get stabbed.

THEO (looked at the stain on his jeans)
I don't know how I ended up here either.

She turned her head slightly and studied him. Not suspicious exactly. More like she was recalculating.

She almost smiled at that. Almost. V was quiet for a moment, then reached into a fold in her jacket. She had this plastic bag with some strange pills inside. She didn't say what it was. She just held it there.

V
I have something that can make that pain go away. Poof. I just need to borrow your phone.

THEO stared at it. His phone was at 5%. His leg was bleeding through his jeans. He had ten dollars and nowhere to be.

He thought about how one second with his eyes off the road had cracked his entire life open. He thought about how every choice he'd made tonight had landed him here, back against a pawn shop wall on Eddy Street, being offered something by a stranger with a clean scrunchie.

THEO
What is it?

V
Something that helps with pain.

THEO
That's not an answer.

V met his eyes.
No, it's not.

Another silence.

THEO (CONT'D)
Why are you helping me?

V (looked out at the street again)
I heard it helps with pain. And honestly…

She paused.

V (CONT'D)
I think I was looking for a reason not to use it myself.

Something about that landed differently than anything else she'd said. It wasn't a performance. It was just true, and she said it the way people say true things when they're too tired to dress it up.

THEO (exhaled slowly)
Fine. Here.

He held out his phone, hand shaking slightly.

THEO (CONT'D)
Password is 050225.

V (took it)
Nice. An iPhone.

THEO
Don't check my Instagram.

V
Why not?

THEO
Worst place to figure somebody out.

V (looked at him)
I'll keep that in mind.

Before THEO could think too hard about what she meant, V pressed the pills into his hand.

THEO (nervously asked)
…Is this some kind of pain killer?

V
Uh… Something like that.

THEO looked down the road he had taken to escape MARCO. He thought that maybe, if he took them, they would give him enough strength to make it to the bus and get out of the city with the ten dollars in his pocket. Without another word, he swallowed them

The effect hit almost instantly.

A violent wave of dizziness hit him so fast he barely had time to breathe. The room tilted. Heat rushed through his body, and suddenly it felt like the floor was slipping out from under him. He reached for something to steady himself.

THEO
W-what did you…

The world tilted. He grabbed at the wall, but his hand found nothing solid. V caught his shoulder before he went sideways, easing him down. He could feel the concrete under him, cold and rough, and then he couldn't feel it anymore.

The pain in his thigh went first. Like someone had simply reached in and removed it. Then the noise of Eddy Street, the arguing men, the dog, the neon hum, it all pulled back like the tide going out. What was left was warm and slow and very far away.

He tried to hold onto her. The scrunchie. The clean pale pink of it against her dirty sleeve. He focused on that.

It was the last thing he saw before everything dissolved into color.

CHAPTER 4: THE DREAM

EXT. EDDY ST - EARLY MORNING

The world didn't just slow down. It melted.

THEO was floating, his body heavy and warm, suspended somewhere between the cold concrete of Eddy Street and the inside of his own mind. The screaming neon signs of the hotel and liquor stores, once a garish headache, now bled together into a canvas of beautiful, impossible color. A haze of sapphire, magenta, and electric yellow that turned the grimy street into a shimmering, futuristic boulevard.

He felt perfectly calm. The pain in his thigh was a distant, irrelevant memory. V was still there, but she was different, lighter, almost ethereal. She hopped effortlessly through the fence and onto the low porch of a closed café, perched on a wooden table and leaning out to watch the stylized street scene. THEO, still heavy, leaned against the fence separating him from her.

V

Seems like everything is working, huh… So let's start from the beginning. My name is V.

THEO

Oh shit… I'm THEO. What did you say your name was again? V?

V

You got it right.

THEO (laugh escaped, sounding distant)

So… V. Like the number five? Or am I just dumb?

She turned her head. Confusion melted into a slow smile. Her sharp, impossibly bright eyes caught the neon light, and something about them hit THEO with a strange familiarity. Like a word he used to know.

V
That's a dumb joke.

THEO
Sh*t…

V
I like it. My name is Veronica. V sounds better. And no, it just means you cleared some space.

THEO
Cleared some space…

THEO
How old are you? Are you like nineteen?

V (blushed and let out a laugh)
Where'd you get that?

THEO
You just seem… I don't know. Younger than me.

V
Twenty-one. So.

THEO (blinked)
I'm twenty.

V
Cool.

A pause. Neither of them seemed bothered by it.

V
What brought you here?

THEO
College. Wanted to get out of Compton and build something.

V
Seems to be going great.

THEO
Yeah.

He looked at the neon blurring above him.

THEO (CONT'D)
Some guy tried to kill me.

V (made a face)
Okay.

THEO
It was a bad day.

V
I'm from up north, too. Also here for… work, actually.

THEO
So how'd you end up with the–

He gestured vaguely.

V
I was going to use it tonight. First time.

She shrugged, but it was a small shrug, like the thought still had some weight to it.

V (CONT'D)
You looked like you needed it more.

THEO
Thanks, I guess.

V
Don't thank me yet. You don't know what tomorrow feels like.

THEO didn't have an answer for that. The colors above him shifted, the yellow bleeding into something softer.

They were quiet for a while. That was the thing about the drug: it didn't make silence feel like something that needed to be fixed.

She hopped back to the street and pulled THEO's hand, guiding him towards the street. THEO followed step-by-step, just focusing on V's hair.

THEO
You know, you are actually really cute… Like so cute…

V blushed but kept on walking and not looking back. Both of them stayed in silence, afraid of breaking it.

V
Bad breakup.

She avoided looking at him, instead focusing down at the pavement.

V (CONT'D)
My friend thought it would help.

THEO
Will it help?

EXT. MARINA BLVD - EARLY MORNING
THEO
You know… I usually run along Marina Boulevard.

V (nudged a loose stone with her shoe as she walked)
Yeah? Got a runner over there?

THEO (tilted his head up slightly)
Boxer, actually. But today… I'd probably just walk.

He let out a slow breath.

THEO (CONT'D)
Blue sky, bright sun, cold air. The kind where it's freezing, but the sunlight still feels warm.

V (glanced at him, looking confused)
You do know it is midnight!

THEO
Exactly

That somehow struck a laugh from V as they passed a dark shop window. V slowed, glancing at their reflection. THEO looked too, barely recognizing himself. He rubbed the back of his neck.

THEO
So who are you exactly?

V (pushed off the glass, a small smile forming_
Let’s see what you're like first… No Insta, right?

She reached into her pocket, pulling out his phone again, scrolling as they walked.

THEO (noticed what was going on)
You still going through that?

V
Mm.

THEO (shook his head slightly)
Or TikTok, they are probably the worst places to figure someone out.

V
Oh yeah? So, what’s the best then?

THEO
Yeah. If you actually want to know someone, check their Pinterest or their music.

V (smirked, slipping the phone back into her pocket)
Good to know. In case I want to do my research. But I like the old-fashioned way more.

THEO let out a quiet laugh. They slowed near a patch of bushes, pushing through a fence.

V
The old-fashioned way, huh? What's your favorite color?

THEO (frowned)
I don't get that question.

V
Why not?

THEO
How do you pick just one?

V (shrugged)
You just do.

THEO glanced around, then stepped off the path, reaching into the bush.

THEO
Hey…

He came back with a slightly bent pale pink rose, similar to her scrunchie, brushing the dirt off it before handing it to her.

THEO
This one is probably your favorite.

V looked at it, then at him. She reached up toward a low branch, going on her toes, trying to pluck a velvet-green leaf.

V
I'm guessing this one's yours.

THEO (nodded)
You wanna trade.

V (smiled)
Deal!

They passed the flower and leaf between them at the same time, her fingers brushing his palm.

THEO
You know…

Dragging his shoe lightly across the stone.

THEO (CONT'D)
The cutest moments always come from the most random time.

V
Like what?

THEO smiled and pinched the rose gently by the stem, then leaned in and tucked it into her hair.

THEO
Like that. When you are tiptoeing.

V blushed and turned around.
Shut up.

They start walking again.

Outside, in the middle of the night, a homeless guy was playing guitar next to them. Trying to make the last few bucks before he could sleep.

The sound was faint but clear enough to pull THEO's attention. The music was rough, a little broken in places, but the music reminds THEO of his last relationship.

That was what caught THEO.

THEO watched his breath in the cold air
You believe in miracles? Or did your standards just get so low that anything feels life-changing if it is different from your daily life?

She didn’t answer right away. Instead, she fiddled with the scrunchie between her fingers, thinking.

V (started slowly)
I do… But people focus too much on fixing things instead of enjoying them.

THEO looked at her, confused.

V (continued, a little more quietly now)
I watched this movie once, *About Time*. The guy could go back and change anything… But the best thing he did wasn’t fixing mistakes… He just went back and lived a normal day again. Being with someone he loved.

She exhaled softly.

V (CONT’D)
That stuck with me.

She glanced at him briefly.

V (CONT’D)
I don’t really care about fixing things anymore…

THEO frowned slightly, the thought slipping through his mind.

THEO
I don’t get it.

V (shrugged)
Think about it. If you had to relive your life… like really relive it… every moment…

She let the thought hang.

V (CONT’D)
You’d want to at least enjoy it rather than finding some problem.

THEO didn’t respond right away.

V (softened)
So how about you? A fixer or an enjoyer.

THEO (hesitated)
No idea what is going on.

They slowed down. V still had his phone in her pocket.

V adjusted her grip on his phone absentmindedly.

V
I don’t usually do this…

THEO glanced at her.

THEO
Do what?

V gestured vaguely.

V
This… Drugs… any kind. I like going out. Exploring. Parties, vaping sometimes… But nothing extreme.

THEO sat down on a bench, flexed his hand, wincing slightly

THEO
Bad breakup. My left ring finger knuckle is broken.

V sat down next to THEO, lightly taking his hand.

V
What?

THEO looked down.

THEO
Boxing… I broke the ring finger a while ago… thought it meant something.

V glanced at him

V
Like what?

THEO gave a faint, dry smile.

THEO
What love had in store for me… I picked up Boxing after a brutal breakup as well. And when my ring finger broke, I guess I thought I was meant to be alone. That mindset stood with me for a very long time.

V didn't let go of his hand.
V
Don’t you have anyone?

THEO (shook his head slightly)

THEO
Not really… I’m just used to it.

V (looked at him)
Yeah, I know. Me too. But do you miss home? Your friends? Your family?

THEO
No. No one is waiting for me back there. That’s why I chose to come here. For a new start that isn't tied down to anything.

V
Doesn’t that get a bit lonely? Being alone and feeling lonely are two different things.

THEO
I don’t really know anymore. I guess I’ve buried it for so long that I can’t tell the difference.

V looked at him for a moment, her thumb brushing lightly over his knuckles.

V
You know… maybe the best kind of therapy isn't fixing anything. Maybe it's just… holding someone.

She shifted a little closer.

V (CONT'D)
Maybe it's just… holding each other for a bit.

A small pause. Before he could respond, she pulled him in. THEO didn't resist.

At first, he just leaned into her, stiff, like he didn't know what to do with it. Then his shoulders just dropped. His breath hitched. And suddenly, he was crying.

V didn't say anything. She just held him. One hand steady on his back, the other resting gently at the side of his head, keeping him close.

THEO's grip tightened for a moment, like he was afraid it would disappear. His breathing evened out. The weight of everything sank away.

And before he even realized it, he fell asleep.

TRIPLE O'S DRIVE-IN - EARLY MORNING.
The light hit his eyes first. THEO flinched, turning his head away, one arm coming up to shield his face. The world bled in slowly after that, shapes, color, the hard edge of morning pressing through whatever haze he had been in.

He pushed himself up from the bench, wincing slightly, his body heavy and unfamiliar. For a second, he just sat there, trying to piece it together, but nothing came.

He looked around. Empty street. Early morning light. Everything is normal. His phone sat beside him, dead. Next to it is the pink scrunchie.

The smell of food pulled him back. His stomach twisted hard enough to decide for him. So he stood, a little unsteady, and made his way inside. THEO picked up everything and got inside.

The cashier looked at him, paused for a second, then gave a small, confused frown.

THE CASHIER
…Rough night?

THEO
I don’t know actually.

The cashier leaned forward slightly, studying him.

THE CASHIER
What happened to you?

Theo rubbed his face, letting out a dry breath.

THEO
I don’t know… I might’ve died, or about to. One of the two.

THE CASHIER
…You good, man?

THEO nodded, though it didn’t look convincing. He opened his mouth to answer.

THEO
I think I just figured out my essay.

THE CASHIER
Your what?

THEO didn’t answer. Instead, he reached into his pocket and dumped everything onto the counter. A crumpled five-dollar bill and a scatter of coins slid forward. He pushed them toward the cashier.

THEO
What can I get for this?

CHAPTER 5: THE JUDGEMENT

INT. THE BLACK SUBURBAN - MORNING
TRACE enjoyed a piece of spring roll.

TRACE
I have to give it to you. Not my ideal last meal. But damn, these spring rolls are good.

THEO sat in the back seat, holding a plastic bowl with four pieces of dim sum. His wrists were still zip-tied in front of him. Steam curled up faintly from the food.

TRACE (shrugged slightly)
Here, LEON, try some.

LEON shoved the spring roll out of TRACE's hand.

LEON
Get that away from me!

TRACE
Hey! That was a perfectly good piece.

LEON
Called itself Jade Garden? That place is a dump. It barely pulls two stars on Google Maps.

A small pause.

THEO
I used to eat here all the time.

No one said anything.

THEO
It's the only place I actually crave when I'm out of town. Doesn't matter where I go.

TRACE looked at THEO through the rear-view mirror.
TRACE

This? This is your last meal?

THEO nodded.

TRACE
It’s consistent.

TRACE (let out a quiet breath)
If I had the choice, I’d go for something bigger. Like that one killer crown.

THEO looked back down at the bowl and picked up one of the dumplings.

THEO
So how did you guys find me?

LEON and TRACE exchanged a look.

LEON (smiled faintly)
The apartment or 30 minutes ago?

THEO
Thirty minutes ago.

LEON shrugged slightly.
It wasn’t hard to find you. After that phone call with MARCO, TRACE went downstairs to get to the fire escape.

TRACE
And, you really f*cked MARCO pretty hard. When I came down, he was just sitting there, saying f*ck this and f*ck that.

He then made a sharp left turn.

TRACE (CONT’D)
Then, I noticed the blood trail that you left behind, so I called LEON.

LEON

We then followed that to Eddy St. and asked a bunch of those crack heads to see if they saw you… One of the f*cking guys said he would tell us for $100.

TRACE
F*ck that guy.

LEON
So TRACE just tossed the money at the guy just to find out that you went with some girl to a park.

TRACE
We spent like two hours driving around until finding out you were entering the f*cking burger place.

He looked at the security guard and signaled him to open the gate.

TRACE (CONT'D)
So we decide to wait until you get out… You know, to cause less public disturbance.

LEON
So, kid, finish up before we get to the mansion. We're almost there.

THEO looked down at the bowl in his hands. Two pieces left. He finished them quickly, accepting what was about to happen. He only hoped he might get the same kind of choice in how his life would end as he did with this last meal.

INT. THE MANSION
LEON opened the door and stepped aside. THEO followed him in.

Dark wood, low lighting, thick curtains that blocked out the outside. Everything was placed with intention. A large desk sat at the center, clean and controlled, with a single lamp casting a warm pool of light.

MR. BISHOP stood near the desk. Big, muscular, filling the space without moving much. He wore a loose set of pajamas, black and red velvet fabric.

THEO straightened slightly, trying to hold himself together.

MR. BISHOP glanced at him, then at LEON. He then turned back toward the desk.

MR. BISHOP
Cut him.

THEO (suddenly panicked)
Please don’t… no… no… no…

LEON (stepped forward)
Holds still.

He clipped the zip ties. THEO’s hands dropped free. He rubbed his wrists slowly, still watching MR. BISHOP.

MR. BISHOP pushed a glass of water across the desk toward THEO. THEO looked at it but did not move. After a moment, MR. BISHOP took it back, drank from it himself, and set it down again.

MR.BISHOP
It’s just water.

THEO hesitated, then reached forward and took a small drink. He lowered the glass slightly

THEO
What’s going on?

MR. BISHOP let out a quiet laugh as he pulled his chair back and sat down. He rested one arm on the desk, relaxed.

MR.BISHOP
Sit!

THEO sat down and listened closely to what is going on.

MR. BISHOP
You hit my son. Left him with a scar. Then you disappear. No visit. No call.

He tapped the desk lightly.

MR. BISHOP (CONT'D)
And on top of that, you stab MARCO.

TRACE leaned against a shelf nearby, reaching for a bottle. He turned it in his hand.

TRACE
To be fair, MARCO probably had it coming.

MR. BISHOP
Put that down.

TRACE smirked, still holding it.
Eighteen-year Scotch. You have good taste.

MR. BISHOP (glanced over)
You have been eyeing that since you got this job, TRACE. Put it down.

TRACE raised his hands slightly and set the bottle back.

THEO closed his eyes and pressed his hand against his forehead. Everything came back at once. The crash. The name. The running. The last few days crashed together all at once.

MR. BISHOP watched him quietly, then spoke.

MR.BISHOP
I just wanted to thank you.

THEO (looked up, confused)
What?

MR. BISHOP (leaned back in his chair)
For helping my son.

A pause settled in the room.

MR. BISHOP (continued, voice calm)
My daughter got hit by a car once, and now her legs won't work because she was discovered too late.

He looked at THEO.

MR.BISHOP (CONT'D)
That guy is not part of our problem anymore.

Silence.

MR. BISHOP (CONT'D)
This time, my son gets hit. And you take him somewhere.

He frowned slightly.

MR. BISHOP (CONT'D)
Why the dentist?

THEO (blinked)
I tried to find the closest hospital.

MR. BISHOP stared at him for a second, then laughed.

MR. BISHOP
Unbelievable. But you helped him and owned up to it. I respect that. Pretty rare these days.

MR. BISHOP took a slow sip from his glass.

MR. BISHOP (CONT'D)
Tommy woke up and told me what happened. Said he was late for class, cut across the road, and you didn't see him in time. Accidents happen.

He set the glass down.

MR. BISHOP (CONT'D)
He also told me that on the way there, he was crying, afraid of death. And, you kept trying to calm him down. Holding his hand, yelling everything was going to be okay.

He looked at THEO.

MR. BISHOP (CONT'D)
That matters.

MR. BISHOP opened a drawer and pulled out a clipboard, sliding it across the desk.

MR. BISHOP (CONT'D)
Next time you want to run, take the paperwork with you.

THEO looked down. His name was still there, along with his address and a phone number he had written down wrong, 3 instead of 8.

MR. BISHOP tapped the paper lightly.
We could've saved a lot of time if you'd written your phone number down properly. A call is a lot easier than an appointment… I recognized you. Underground fights.

THEO stayed quiet.

MR. BISHOP leaned back, studying him.

MR. BISHOP (CONT'D)
MARCO did not tell me the full story. He never does. But I can see it.

He paused.

MR. BISHOP (CONT'D)
You have something. You have fire.

LEON stood near the door, arms crossed, watching.

MR. BISHOP pulled out another sheet of paper along with a pen. He set them in front of THEO.

MR. BISHOP
I am not going to kill you.

THEO’s shoulders tighten. He braces for the catch.

MR. BISHOP (CONT'D)
But you owe me.

THEO looked down at his shoe, scared.
How much?

MR. BISHOP
Ten fights.

[SMASH CUT TO:]

INT. UNDERGROUND RING - FLASH - NIGHT
CRACK!

A massive leather glove slams square into THEO’s jaw. THEO’s head violently snaps back, sweat and blood spraying in slow, harsh light. The roar of a screaming crowd erupts.

[SMASH CUT BACK TO:]

INT. THE MANSION - MORNING
THEO flinches slightly in his chair, blinking the phantom sting out of his eyes.

THEO
Can I do five?

MR. BISHOP stared him up and down
Ten.

[SMASH CUT TO:]

INT. UNDERGROUND RING - FLASH - NIGHT
A sledgehammer hook drives deep into Theo’s liver. Theo folds in half, knees buckling beneath him, a harsh, agonized gasp ripped from his chest.

[SMASH CUT BACK TO:]

INT. THE MANSION - MORNING
Theo sits bent forward, hand pressed over his ribs where the ghost of the punch landed. Bishop leans in, his voice velvet and cold.

MR. BISHOP
No more. No less.

THEO
Why this? Why put me in a cage?

MR. BISHOP
The bruises. The hits.

[SMASH CUT TO:]

INT. UNDERGROUND RING - FLASH - NIGHT
THEO gets hammered into the ropes. An uppercut jolts him upright. He spits red onto the blood-smeared canvas.

REFEREE (O.S.)
...FOUR! FIVE!

[SMASH CUT BACK TO:]

INT. THE MANSION - MORNING
MR. BISHOP
That is the price you are paying back to me.

Bishop slides the clean, white contract across the mahogany desk. A black pen rolls to a stop beside Theo’s shaking fingers.

MR. BISHOP (CONT'D)
I will provide the training. To keep the match entertaining. So take the deal.

LEON steps forward from the doorway, crossing his arms.

LEON
Just sign kid.

THEO stares at the blank signature line. His hand hovers over the pen for one agonizing beat. He picks it up and scrawls his name.

Mr. Bishop smiles faintly, pulling the paper back.

MR. BISHOP
Ten rounds… Let’s see what you’re made of.

EXT. THEO’S APARTMENT - NOON
LEON opened the door and gave THEO a look before he stepped out.

LEON
Don’t do anything stupid… Keep your phone on. I’ll be in touch.

TRACE leaned back in his seat, half-smiling.

TRACE
Try not to run this time. The stitches are still fresh.

THEO didn’t answer. He stepped out, the door shutting behind him as the car pulled away without another word.

The street was quiet. THEO stood there for a second, then turned and walked toward his place.

He walked out of the apartment, entered the side alley, and entered the fire escape. Cold metal under his hands as he climbed, slower than usual. The rusted metal creaks. He pulled himself up and slipped through the window.

His room felt just the same as he left it. Messy. Quiet. Safe, in a way that didn’t feel real anymore.

He dropped onto the couch and reached for his charger, plugging his phone in. The screen stayed black for a second, then flickered to life.

Notifications flooded in. Messages. Emails. Deadlines.
One stood out.

“PHIL 101
Assignment Due Today (11:59 PM)
Free Will vs. Determinism essays
1,000–1,500 words.”

THEO stared at it for a moment, then looked away.

He leaned back, rubbing his face, then opened SoundCloud.

He opened the app and scrolled without thinking, then paused.

A new playlist. He didn’t recognize it. No name. Just a string of numbers. Three digits short of a phone number. There was only one song inside. He pressed play.

“Strange Land (Acoustic Version)” by Niki & 88rising

The room remained quiet as the music filled it, immediately after the advertisement for a new toothpaste branch.

THEO leaned back in his chair, eyes half-closed, the strange familiarity lingering as he drifted off to sleep.

CHAPTER 6: THE DAWN

INT. UNDERGROUND BOXING GYM - NIGHT

By the sixth and final round of his tenth fight, THEO was running on his last energy from a single grilled cheese he had eaten two hours before the opening bell.

His lungs were burning, his mouth was open, and every breath through the mouthguard came out wet and bloody. His legs still moved, but only because they had to, or a knockout was coming.

His left eye was narrowing under swelling. His ribs hurt on both sides. His right forearm was dead from blocking hooks. His left shoulder had been tugged, clipped, and yanked on so many times that even holding the hand high felt like work.

Across from him, DIEGO looked like the bigger man because he was the bigger man. Thicker through the chest. Heavier in the clinch. Shorter punches. Less wasted motion.

THEO had already been knocked down six times.

DIEGO had gone down two.

That was why the crowd was losing its mind. THEO could feel the canvas under his boots, damp and slightly tacky from sweat. The lights over the ring were starting to blind him. Somewhere outside the ropes, men were screaming with money in their hands.

The bell rang.

DIEGO took the center immediately.

He came out behind a hard, measuring jab, not flicking it, but stepping into it. His lead foot landed outside THEO’s, taking away the easy exit. THEO saw it and gave ground at once, circling to his own left, trying not to let himself get squared up near the ropes.

DIEGO jabbed high.

THEO slipped outside.

DIEGO doubled it right away, the second jab lower and stiffer, and that one caught THEO on the forehead and stopped the escape.

That was enough.

DIEGO drove a right hand into THEO’s body, not clean, but heavy enough through the elbow to fold his posture and steal the breath he had left. THEO took a step back and felt the ropes brush his calves.

Bad place.

DIEGO knew it too.

He walked him in properly. Small steps. Balanced feet. Hands in position.

Left hook to the guard.

Right hand over the top.

Short left hook under the elbow.

THEO shelled up, chin tucked to chest, right glove stapled to temple, left elbow pinched down over the ribs. He was not blocking clean. He was just choosing where to get hurt.

DIEGO kept digging.

Another left to the body. This one is lower, curling around the elbow.

THEO grunted.

DIEGO brought the right uppercut right up the middle after it. THEO caught part of it on the gloves, but the shot still jolted his head back, making the lights flash.

The crowd roared.

THEO leaned into the ropes. He waited for DIEGO to overcommit, then jammed a short frame with his right forearm across DIEGO's collarbone, bought a sliver of space, and pivoted off to his left.

TYSON (THEO's coach)
Good move.

DIEGO turned with him fast and cut him off before THEO could fully reset.

THEO jabbed to the chest to slow him down.

DIEGO parried it inward.

THEO threw the right hand over the top anyway.

It landed mostly on the forehead and the glove, but it was enough to make DIEGO blink. THEO stepped in behind it and ripped a short left hook to the body, then came back upstairs with the same hand.

That one landed clean.

Not huge, but clean enough to turn DIEGO's head and bring the sound back out of the room.

THEO felt it.

DIEGO answered immediately with a jab that split the guard and a right hand to the chest that knocked THEO backward two steps. THEO tried to plant after it, but his feet were too slow now. He crossed them for a second.

DIEGO saw it and threw the left hook.

THEO barely rolled under it, came up bent at the waist, and shot a right hand to the ribs.

Good placement. But not enough on it.

DIEGO took it, lowered his elbow, and shoved THEO’s head down with the lead forearm. Dirty enough to matter. Legal enough that the referee let it go.

THEO tried to come up and clinch.

DIEGO dug the left hand into the body again before THEO could tie him properly.

That shot landed.

Deep.

THEO’s knees dipped, and the whole side of his body tightened like it was trying to protect itself from the inside.

DIEGO stepped in hard to finish the exchange, chest almost on THEO now, and started working in the pocket.

Short right uppercut.

Left hook to the arms.

Right hand over the top.

THEO stayed in the shell and tried to ride the impact with small turns of his shoulders, taking some on the glove, some on the forearm, some on the side of the head. It was painful and exactly the kind of thing people paid to see.

Then DIEGO got greedy.

He widened his feet to throw the next left hook harder.

THEO saw the weight shift. He dipped inside it and ripped a compact right hook across the jaw.

DIEGO dropped to a knee.

The room exploded.

THEO stepped back, breathing through his mouth, gloves half raised, chest pumping. He could feel his own pulse in his lips and behind his eyes. For one second, with DIEGO kneeling and the referee counting, none of the pain mattered.

Then DIEGO got up at eight, and THEO saw the look on his face.

DIEGO came off the count behind a stiff double jab that forced THEO straight back. THEO tried to circle, but the feet were not there anymore. The first jab touched the guard. The second jab split it. Then came the right hand to the solar plexus.

THEO folded and instinctively lowered his elbows.

DIEGO went upstairs at once.

Left hook to the temple.

Right uppercut through the middle.

THEO’s head snapped back. His boots skidded. He stayed up by pure habit.

He threw a desperate left hook in reply, but the shoulder had too much slack in it now. The punch came wide and slow.

DIEGO slipped outside and slammed a straight right onto THEO’s left side, half shoulder, half chest.

THEO felt something shift. Not fully yet. Just enough to send a hot warning down the arm.

He backed up to buy time, but DIEGO did not let him breathe.

Jab high.

Hook low.

Right hand upstairs.

Everything came in sequence. Everything was built on the last shot. It was not reckless brawling anymore. It was a big man with enough gas left to punish a smaller one.

THEO tried to answer with the jab.

It touched.

He stepped in behind it and threw his right hand clean down the pipe.

DIEGO’s head snapped back. THEO followed with a left hook, and this time the shoulder betrayed him.

The arm came over wrong, extended too far, and as DIEGO tried to pull away while THEO’s glove and forearm were still tangled on him, the joint got dragged out of line.

A sick pop. Sharp. Deep.

THEO’s whole left side went hot.

His arm dropped. He sucked air through his teeth to hold back the pain, a hiss so hard it sounded like steam escaping a pipe.

DIEGO noticed immediately. He stepped to THEO’s damaged side and hammered a right hand right into the shoulder.

THEO nearly went to a knee from that alone.

The pain shot from the joint into his neck and fingers. The whole arm felt suddenly long and useless.

The crowd was screaming now because they could tell something had happened.

THEO turned the left side away and kept the right glove high. He could not throw the left properly anymore, so he used it as a frame, as a touch, as something to stop DIEGO from walking straight through him.

DIEGO pinned him near a neutral corner.

Left hook to the body.

Right uppercut inside.

Short left on the exit.

THEO took the body shot, blocked the uppercut badly, and answered with a right cross that clipped the ear and cheek. It bought him one step. He took it. Then another.

DIEGO jabbed him back into place.

THEO's face was a mess now. Blood at the mouth. Swelling under both eyes. Nose running. His breath had lost all rhythm. In through the mouth. Out whenever pain forced it.

DIEGO planted and ripped another left to the body, this time right under the elbow on the already tender side. THEO bent. DIEGO brought the right over the top and smashed it into the side of THEO's head.

THEO hit the ropes and stayed there.

DIEGO started pouring it on.

Hooks on the arms. Straight shots between the gloves. A right hand to the shoulder again.

THEO tried to roll with the head shots and absorb the rest with his guard, but there was only so much of him left to give. Every impact shook through his frame. His forearms were numb. His ribs were throbbing. The left shoulder hung low and ugly.

Then THEO saw something.

Small. Brief. Enough.

DIEGO was punching in rhythm now. Jab. Right hand. Left hook.

THEO waited through the jab.

Slipped the right.

And before the left hook could come all the way around, he cracked DIEGO with a short right hook on the jaw.

He followed with a straight right down the middle.

DIEGO took a full step back.

Not hurt badly, but checked.

Even when losing, even when breaking apart, THEO kept finding these tiny violent proofs that he belonged there.

Then DIEGO took it back.

He feinted low, brought THEO’s elbow down, then whipped the left hook high to the temple. THEO never saw all of it. The shot twisted him sideways. Before he could recover, DIEGO drove a right hand into his ribs and then another to the shoulder.

THEO sagged into the ropes. His legs were barely standing.

The bell had still not come.

That was the worst part. Those last seconds when the body was convinced time had stopped just to watch you drown in it.

DIEGO kept punching. Not sloppy. Not wild. Just cruel and correct.

THEO kept trying to answer. A jab that looked more like a push. A right hand that landed on the forehead and slid off.

Then the bell rang.

THEO turned toward his corner and nearly missed the stool entirely. Two cornermen had to take him under the arms and guide him the rest of the way.

THEO sat there with blood on his mouth, one eye swelling, his left shoulder visibly wrong, and both gloves dangling over his thighs. He had clearly lost.

The crowd stayed on its feet.

They knew who won.

They also knew what they had just watched.

THE ANNOUNCER (shoute)
Ladies and gentlemen, after six rounds, we go to the judges' scorecards.

Boos. Cheers. Whistles.

THE ANNOUNCER (raised his arm)
Your winner by unanimous decision... DIEGO!

The gym burst apart again. DIEGO lifted both gloves and turned slowly in a circle, soaking it in.

THEO stayed on the stool. Of course, he lost.

The miracle was not the result. The miracle was that he had still made the room believe there might be one.

Only after the announcement did the coach kneel in front of him. He was not loud like the other cornermen. He did not scream strategy just to hear himself sound important. He moved with the calm of someone who had seen too many boys come apart under bright lights and bad odds.

He crouched low, one hand under THEO's elbow, one at the shoulder.

TYSON
Don’t move yet.

THEO (tried to laugh and winced)
Wasn’t planning on it.

TYSON checked the joint with two careful fingers and exhaled through his nose.

TYSON
It slipped.

THEO
I noticed.

TYSON
Good. Means the head shots didn’t take everything.

He pressed lightly around the shoulder, feeling how far the bone had shifted. THEO’s face tightened. He had started to think the fights were built for him to take a beating. He kept drawing heavier men. Harder men. Men who could make him feel the size difference in every clinch. He knew now MR. BISHOP had arranged it.

But the coach was real. MR. BISHOP had actually given him somebody who knew what he was doing. Not a gambler. Not one of the drunk ex-fighters who talked about their past like they missed it.

A real coach. The kind who made him drill the jab until it came back to his cheek without thought. The kind who corrected the angle of a hook, the timing of a slip, the placement of a right hand, until THEO could feel himself becoming harder to kill in there.

TYSON slid one arm behind THEO’s back.

TYSON
This is going to hurt.

THEO
Yeah.

TYSON
Breathe out.

TYSON pulled and turned. The shoulder slid back into place but made THEO suck air through his teeth and grip the edge of the stool with both taped hands.

For a second, he thought he might throw up.

THEO sat there blinking fast, jaw tight. Coach grabbed an ice pack from one of the cornermen and pressed it to the shoulder.

TYSON
You gave away too much ground early. But the hook was clean tonight. Shorter now. You're finally not swinging it from the parking lot.

THEO managed the tiniest smile through busted lips.

TYSON stood and looked down at him.

TYSON
You can fight. That's obvious. The problem is you still think heart is a substitute for defense.

THEO leaned his head back against the corner pad.

THEO
Sometimes it is.

TYSON (snorted)
Only if the other guy gets tired of hitting you first.

A cornerman started cutting the tape from THEO's gloves. Coach folded the ice pack harder into his shoulder and lowered his voice a little.

TYSON
You’re starting to see it, aren’t you?

THEO looked up.

TYSON tilted his head toward the ring, where DIEGO was still receiving congratulations.

TYSON
The matchups.

THEO (not answer right away. Then, quietly)
Yeah.

TYSON
“Then get better faster.”

THEO sat with that while the gym kept moving around him. The truth was ugly because it was mixed with something useful.

He was being punished, but he was also being made into something sharper.

That was the part he hated knowing.

EXT. THE BOXING GYM - JACKSON SQUARE - LATE NIGHT
THEO stepped out through the side door with a backpack slung over one shoulder and his earphones in one hand. His face had already started to stiffen. The swelling around the eye felt tighter by the minute. His shoulder was taped under his hoodie.

Behind him, the gym still throbbed through the wall with crowd noise.

A guy smoking under the awning looked him over and gave a short nod.

THE GUY
Good fight tonight.

THEO slipped one earbud in.

THEO
Thanks.

Then he put the other on and started walking.

Jackson Square is like a scene from the past, lined with tall red-brick buildings and trees. A wide pathway of reddish bricks sweeps across the ground.

People walked casually along the sidewalk, passing cozy restaurants with large glass windows. You can see the soft, warm flicker of candles on every table, making the whole street feel cozy.

THEO walked through it like a man too tired to admire anything properly.

Reaching into his backpack, he pulled out a can of tuna. He rolled it across his palm, then tossed it up and caught it. It was a dumb habit, but it gave his hand something to do.

He was halfway down the block when he heard his name.

ERIC
THEO?

THEO looked up.

Standing outside one of the restaurants near the window was ERIC, someone from his math class two years ago, dressed cleaner now, one hand stuffed in his coat pocket.

Beside him stood a girl THEO had never seen before, her arm looped through his. She had a polished look.

ERIC blinked, then laughed in disbelief.

ERIC
No way.

THEO (smiled tiredly)
ERIC.

ERIC stepped forward and gave him a quick one-armed hug before pulling back.

ERIC
Dude, what happened to your face?

The girl beside him looked even closer.

ERIC
And why are your eyes blue?

THEO touched under one eye and winced.

THEO
Just finished a boxing match.

ERIC
Boxing?

THEO
Yeah. Long night.

ERIC (laughed)
Man, I did not picture that for you at all.

THEO (shrugged)
Most people don’t.

ERIC (turned slightly)
This is my girlfriend, AMY. And this is my friend, THEO.

AMY (gave a small smile)
Hi.

THEO
Hey.

For a second, the three of them just stood there in the restaurant glow.

ERIC
So what are you doing now?

THEO adjusted the backpack on his good shoulder.

THEO
Editorial assistant at a local newspaper. Mostly assisting. Editing little pieces. Cleaning stuff up.

ERIC (stared)
You?

THEO laughed softly.
Yeah.

ERIC
You were in commerce.

THEO
I know. Have a little change of plan.

ERIC pointed at him like thought he caught THEO in a lie.

ERIC
I thought you were gonna end up in banking or some office.

THEO leaned a little more weight onto his back foot.

THEO
No. I thought that too for a while.

ERIC
So what changed?

THEO glanced down the street, then back at him.

THEO
One philosophy essay I wrote back then. Free will versus determinism.

ERIC squinted.

THEO
Got a B-. I know that professor is full of sh*t, so I posted that online. Somebody at the paper liked it. One thing led to another. I started helping out. Then I stayed.

ERIC (shook his head, still amused)
That is insane.

THEO (smiled)
Probably.

AMY looked at him a little differently now.
“That’s actually kind of nice.”

ERIC (smirked)
Yeah, okay. Unexpected, but nice.

THEO slipped the tuna can back into his backpack, then changed his mind and pulled it right back out again.

ERIC (noticed and laughed)
Is that your dinner?

THEO (looked at the can)
It’s for my good friend. My half is back home.

AMY covered a smile with the back of her hand.

ERIC
Man, I don’t know whether to be worried or impressed.

THEO
Go with both.

AMY felt a tug at her sleeve from inside the restaurant as someone cracked the door to call for the next table. She looked back.

AMY
Our table’s ready.

ERIC glanced over his shoulder, then back to THEO.

ERIC
Damn. Okay. Good seeing you, though. Seriously.

THEO
You too.

ERIC pointed at his own eye.

ERIC
Ice that.

THEO (nodded)
That’s the plan.

AMY (smiled at him once more)
Goodnight, THEO.

THEO
Night.

They disappeared inside, swallowed by warm light and polished glass.

THEO kept walking. After a few steps, a line came to him, the kind that felt less like a thought and more like the beginning of something he might suggest at the next meeting.

THEO (talked to himself)
San Francisco feels like a small town and a big city at the same time. You can bump into a friend you made and didn’t think you’d ever see again, but I still never seem to see her again, while the person you actually hope to see remains lost.

He let the idea sit in his head for a moment, then kept walking.

The tuna can went up into the air and dropped back into his hand. A small metallic click each time his fingers closed around it.

Up again.

Caught.

EXT. THEO'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

By the time he took the sharp left onto his block, the street had thinned out. Fewer windows were lit. Fewer voices. Just old brick, a weak yellow lamp over the side entrance, and the corner of his building waiting the same way it always did.

THEO entered the alley next to the apartment. He crouched before he even reached the door.

THEO
There you are.

A black cat lifted its head from the base of the wall.

It was a small thing with a nicked ear and a street-smart face. It looked like it had just finished judging everyone nearby and found them wanting.

THEO popped the can open and set it down near the wall. The cat stepped over carefully, sniffed once, then started eating.

THEO leaned down and petted the top of its head.

THEO (CONT'D)
How are you doing, Milo?

Milo ignored the question in the professional way only cats could.

THEO slid down the wall and sat beside him, head leaning back against the brick. The shoulder hurt. Everything hurt. He watched the cat pull the can closer to THEO with one paw, then settle beside him while eating.

THEO (laughed quietly)
Yeah, I'm hungry too, buddy. Tough night.

He pulled out his phone.

A voice message from LEON.

THEO stared at it for a second, then opened it.

LEON (O.S)
Nice work today, kid. You made a lot of money. The crowd loved the way you kept getting up. MR. BISHOP says that right hook in the last round made everybody forget the score for a second, which is good business. Listen, kid, we know you finished the matches, but MR. BISHOP is offering you...

THEO closed it before LEON could keep talking.

He sat still for a second. Then, before anything else, he unlocked his phone and reached into his backpack for a notebook.

The cover was bent at the corners and soft from being handled too much. Inside, page after page of numbers from 000 to 999.

Line after line crossed out in dark pen. All the way to 783.

THEO stared at the page for a moment, then dialed the next number. He put the phone to his ear.
It rang. Once. Twice.

Then a voice answered. Old. Careful.

A GIRL
Hello?

THEO (swallowed)
Hi, is this V?

A small pause.

A GIRL
This is AMY. Who are you?

THEO shut his eyes.

THEO
Sorry. Wrong number.

He ended the call and lowered the phone.

For a second, he just sat there with it in his hand, the screen dimming.

THEO looked down at Milo.

THEO (CONT'D)
Yup. Another miss.

He scratched the cat gently down the back.

THEO (CONT'D)
Pretty sad, right?

Milo licked tuna from his whiskers, climbed, and settled down on THEO's lap.

THEO looked at the notebook again.

THEO (CONT'D)
One phone call a day.

He muttered.

THEO (CONT'D)
Promise you last month, Milo.

He let the notebook hang loose for a moment before crossing out the number. Using his right hand, he pushed himself up from the wall.

Milo jumped down and looked up at him.

THEO took two steps toward the door. Then he heard it.
A meow.

He turned.

Milo was standing now, looking at him.

THEO blinked.

Then the cat took a few quick steps forward and meowed again.

THEO (laughed, tired and a little surprised)
Ohh. You want to come with me now.

He looked at the notebook in his hand. All those crossed-out numbers. All that hope spent on strangers' voices.

He stared at it one second longer, then said, softly,

THEO
Uhh… F*ck it.

He tossed the notebook into the trash bin beside the side entrance.

Then he bent down, scooped Milo up carefully against his chest, and stood with the cat tucked in one arm.

Milo stiffened for exactly one second, then settled like this had been his decision all along.

THEO (smiled despite himself)
Alright. Come on then.

He opened the door and stepped into the building with the cat in his arms, shoulder aching, face swollen, and earphones still hanging around his neck.

THEO started walking up the stairs. Milo looked around once, then tucked closer against him.

When he reached his floor, he fumbled with his keys, finally getting the door open, and stepped into the quiet darkness of his apartment.

He set Milo down gently on the worn wood floor. The cat took a few quick steps, tail twitching, before hopping onto the small kitchen counter, where he sat like a small, fuzzy statue, watching THEO.

THEO went straight to the fridge, took out a bottle of water and a carton of eggs, and set them on the counter. He moved slowly, careful not to strain his taped shoulder. Then he filled a small pot with water and placed it on the electric coil burner.

While the water came to a boil, he rooted through a cupboard, pulling out two Indomie noodle packages. Milo sat motionless, eyes fixed entirely on THEO.

THEO (his swollen lip curled into a tired smile)
What, you never saw someone cooked before?

When the water was raging, THEO dropped the two bricks of noodles into the pot. He let it boil down, longer than usual, until the strands were swollen and super soft, exactly how he wanted them.

He cracked three eggs directly into the roiling water, letting the yolks bloom while the whites barely set, no more than half a minute.

Then he carried the pot to the sink, drained it, and returned it to the counter. After that, he opened the fridge and grabbed a can of tuna.

THEO held it up to the cat.

THEO
This is your gift, Milo.

A wet kitchen towel went onto the coffee table first, then the warm pot of noodles. The open can of tuna went beside it for Milo. He turned on the TV, and Spirited Away was playing.

THEO sat on the couch, grabbed his chopsticks, and opened the seasoning packets—chili, oil, powder, dropping all of it directly into the pot. He used the chopsticks to mash everything together. He didn't bother with a bowl.

Milo, having watched the entire process, settled onto the coffee table. THEO leaned forward, elbows resting on his knees, and ate directly from the pot, steam rising around his face as the TV flickered quietly in the background. For a while, the two of them just sat next to each other and ate.